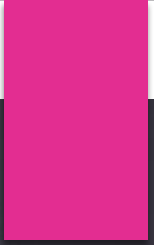


The Zardari Era (2008-2013)

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The **Zardari Era (2008-2013)** refers to the period during which **Asif Ali Zardari**, co-chairman of the **Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP)**, served as the **11th President of Pakistan**. Zardari assumed the presidency in the aftermath of the **tragic assassination of his wife, Benazir Bhutto**, in December 2007 and the PPP's victory in the **2008 general elections**. His five-year tenure was marked by a series of **political, economic, and social challenges** and significant **developments in Pakistan's democracy**. Zardari navigated a country recovering from military rule, struggling with terrorism, political instability, and an ailing economy. While his presidency saw critical **constitutional reforms** and some social welfare initiatives, it was also marred by corruption and allegations of governance failure s. Zardari's leadership style and decisions during this period helped shape Pakistan's trajectory in the 21st century. Still, his time in office also sparked deep debates about the country's future and the role of democratic institutions.



Key Facts and Events of the Zardari Era

Political Landscape and Zardari's Rise to Power

2008 General Elections: Under Zardari's leadership, the PPP won a majority in the National Assembly in the 2008 general elections. This victory marked the return of civilian rule after **Pervez Musharraf's resignation** and the end of military-backed governance. The PPP formed a **coalition government** with several other parties, including the **Pakistan Muslim League-Nawaz (PML-N)**, **Muttahida Qaumi Movement (MQM)**, and **Awami National Party (ANP)**.

Zardari's Presidency: Zardari was elected president on **September 9, 2008**, with the backing of his coalition partners. Though his reputation was tainted by corruption allegations—particularly the **Swiss corruption cases**—he maintained political resilience and emerged as the leader of the PPP after Benazir Bhutto's assassination.

Coalition Politics: Zardari's government faced ongoing tensions with coalition partners, especially **Nawaz Sharif's PML-N**. However, his ability to balance various political forces allowed him to keep his government intact, albeit with fragile alliances.

The War on Terror and National Security

Pakistan's Role in the U.S. War on Terror: Zardari's tenure was heavily influenced by the ongoing **War on Terror**. Pakistan's role in the conflict, particularly its operations against the **Taliban** and **al-Qaeda**, was critical in shaping relations with the United States and NATO. The **Pakistani Taliban (TTP)**, particularly in regions like **Swat** and **FATA**, became increasingly active during Zardari's presidency, leading to significant military operations.

Military Operations: The **Swat Valley Operation (2009)**, which involved military intervention against Taliban insurgents, was a significant event. Pakistan's military managed to restore control in the area, but the broader **insurgency in FATA** continued to destabilize large parts of the country.

Drone Strikes: The use of **U.S. drone strikes** in the tribal regions was a controversial issue. These strikes, aimed at eliminating militants, led to strained relations between Pakistan and the U.S., with many Pakistanis viewing them as a violation of sovereignty. The situation worsened after the **Abbottabad Raid** in 2011, when U.S. Navy SEALs killed **Osama bin Laden** in a compound near Pakistan's military academy, raising questions about Pakistan's complicity in harboring terrorists.

Economic Challenges

Impact of the Global Financial Crisis: The **2007-2008 global financial crisis** significantly impacted Pakistan's economy. Zardari's government struggled to stabilize the economy, dealing with **rising inflation**, a **growing fiscal deficit**, and **declining foreign exchange reserves**. The **GDP growth** slowed down, and the country faced economic stagnation.

IMF Bailouts: Faced with a dire financial situation, Zardari's government entered into agreements with the **International Monetary Fund (IMF)** for loans, resulting in **austerity measures** such as **tax hikes** and **subsidy cuts** that sparked public protests.

Energy Crisis: The country also faced a severe **energy crisis**, with **electricity shortages** and frequent **power outages**. These issues were exacerbated by underinvestment in infrastructure and corruption within state-owned energy companies.

The 18th Amendment and Constitutional Reforms

18th Amendment (2010): One of the critical achievements of Zardari's presidency was the passing of the **18th Amendment** in April 2010, a significant overhaul of the **Pakistani Constitution**. It:

- **Reduced presidential powers**, stripping the president of the ability to dissolve the National Assembly and appoint critical officials without parliamentary approval.
- **Restored the parliamentary governance system, strengthening the Prime Minister's role.**
- **Devolved powers to provinces**, granting them greater autonomy, which was particularly important for smaller provinces like **Baluchistan** and **Khyber Pakhtunkhwa**.

Restoration of the Judiciary: The amendment also restored **the judiciary**, which Musharraf had dismissed. This was part of the **Lawyers' Movement**, which called for the reinstatement of **Chief Justice Iftikhar Muhammad Chaudhry**, who was seen as a symbol of judicial independence.

Natural Disasters and Humanitarian Challenges

2010 Pakistan Floods: One of the most devastating events of Zardari's presidency was the **2010 floods**, which affected over **20 million people** across **Sindh, Punjab, and Khyber Pakhtunkhwa**. The floods caused **massive destruction** to homes, crops, and infrastructure and were considered the worst disaster in Pakistan's history. The government's slow and ineffective response to the crisis drew widespread criticism.

2011 Earthquake: Zardari's administration also had to manage the aftermath of a deadly **earthquake in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa**, adding to the country's fragile humanitarian situation.

Foreign Relations

U.S.-Pakistan Relations: The relationship with the U.S. was tense throughout Zardari's presidency, particularly after the **Abbottabad raid** and the increase in **U.S. drone strikes** in tribal areas. The Pakistani public viewed these strikes as violations of sovereignty, leading to protests and a souring of public opinion towards Washington.

Pakistan-China Relations: Zardari sought to strengthen ties with **China**, particularly in the areas of **trade** and **military cooperation**. The **China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC)** was a significant part of this strategic relationship, although it was formalized after Zardari left office.

India Relations: Zardari's government was cautious in its relations with India. While there were attempts at **diplomatic dialogue**, the relationship remained strained due to issues like **Kashmir** and continued cross-border terrorism.

Corruption Allegations and Public Discontent

Corruption Scandals: Zardari's tenure was marred by corruption allegations. He was nicknamed "Mr. 10 Percent" due to accusations that he had received kickbacks during Benazir Bhutto's tenure as Prime Minister. The Swiss corruption cases, which accused him of money laundering, were a significant source of controversy throughout his presidency. Despite legal challenges, Zardari maintained his position, citing a lack of substantial evidence.

Public Perception: Zardari's popularity declined sharply over the years due to growing dissatisfaction with the government's failure to address issues like **economic instability**, **power shortages**, and **poor governance**. The PPP's image suffered from its association with corruption and inefficiency, and Zardari was often criticized for lacking his late wife's charisma and leadership qualities.

Social Welfare and Public Initiatives

Benazir Income Support Programme (BISP): One of Zardari's key social welfare initiatives was the **Benazir Income Support Programme (BISP)**, launched in 2008. This program provided cash transfers to millions of low-income families, particularly women, and aimed to reduce poverty. During his presidency, BISP became one of Pakistan's most prominent social safety nets.

Education and Healthcare: Despite challenges, Zardari's government made modest efforts to improve **education** and **healthcare**, including the **National Health Policy** and educational reforms. However, Pakistan's performance in both sectors remained poor compared to regional standards.

End of Zardari's Presidency

2013 General Elections: In the **2013 general elections**, Zardari's PPP was defeated by **Nawaz Sharif's PML-N**, which won a clear majority in the National Assembly. Zardari did not seek re-election and chose not to contest the presidential election.

Peaceful Transition of Power: Zardari's tenure ended with the **first peaceful power transfer** between two civilian governments in Pakistan's history. Zardari handed the presidency to **Mamnoon Hussain**, who the new parliament elected.

conclusion

The **Zardari Era (2008-2013)** was a time of highs and lows, full of complex challenges and tough decisions. When **Asif Ali Zardari** took office as president after his wife **Benazir Bhutto's** tragic assassination, the country was in a fragile state—reeling from the aftermath of military rule, facing an unstable economy, and battling the growing threat of terrorism. Despite the weight of these issues, Zardari's presidency was marked by significant achievements and criticism.

On the positive side, Zardari played a key role in pushing through the **18th Amendment** in 2010, a crucial step in **strengthening Pakistan's democracy**. Reducing presidential powers and enhancing parliamentary authority helped pave the way for a more balanced political system. He also launched the **Benazir Income Support Programme (BISP)**, which provided financial assistance to millions of Pakistan's poorest citizens, becoming a lifeline for many families.

However, his time in office was far from smooth. His administration struggled with **corruption allegations**, and despite the ambitious reforms, the country faced persistent challenges, including **rampant inflation, energy shortages, and lawlessness in cities like Karachi**. The floods of 2010, which displaced millions of people, exposed the government's slow response and inability to manage such large-scale disasters effectively, leading to criticism from the public and the media.

Zardari also faced mounting tensions with Pakistan's **international allies**, particularly the U.S., after the **Abbottabad raid** in 2011, when **American Navy SEALs killed Osama bin Laden** on Pakistani soil. This created diplomatic fallout and strained relations with Washington, while the drone strikes in the tribal areas continued to fuel public resentment.

Despite these hurdles, Zardari managed to keep his coalition government intact and saw through a **peaceful power transfer** when his term ended in 2013. This marked a historic moment for Pakistan's democracy—an achievement in itself, given its turbulent political history.

Ultimately, the Zardari era was a mix of **promise and disappointment**, with moments of hope and reform tempered by political infighting, economic stagnation, and ongoing corruption scandals. While he may not have left behind the kind of lasting legacy that some expected, his presidency was nonetheless a significant chapter in Pakistan's evolving democratic journey.